

Notes: Adger, Ross, and Sloan (AER, 2026)

The Effect of Field Training Officers on Police Use of Force

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Does a recruit’s exposure to a more aggressive field training officer (FTO) affect the recruit’s later propensity to use force?
- **Setting.** The paper studies Dallas Police Department recruits and FTOs, using administrative data on calls for service, force reports, arrest records, district attorney filing data, and officer characteristics from 2013 to 2019.
- **Treatment.** The key treatment is the recruit’s first FTO’s prior propensity to use force, measured before the recruit-FTO pairing and standardized after empirical Bayes shrinkage.
- **Identification.** Dallas recruits have no discretion over their initial FTO assignment. Conditional on academy cohort by division, the paper argues that assignments are as good as random.
- **Main result.** A one standard deviation increase in FTO force propensity raises recruit force use by about 14 to 18 percent after training.
- **Persistence.** Effects are positive for roughly two years after the end of training and then attenuate.
- **First FTO matters most.** The first FTO is emphasized because this is the recruit’s first exposure to service, the recruit later returns to this FTO for final evaluation, and only the first FTO has a large and statistically significant effect in the paper’s supplementary checks.
- **Mechanism.** The preferred interpretation is knowledge or norm transfer about the appropriate threshold for applying force. The evidence is less consistent with pure selection into dangerous calls, post-training partners, FTO demographics, report writing, or a general proactive-policing channel.
- **Policy implication.** FTO selection can be a low-cost lever for changing future officer behavior. The authors’ simulation suggests replacing high-force FTOs with low-force FTOs could reduce recruit force incidents by about 10.6 percent.
- **Important caution.** The force measure captures a propensity to use force, not whether force was legally justified, socially desirable, or undesirable in any specific case. The paper stays agnostic about the socially optimal amount of force.

2 Data and measurement

2.1 Institutional setting: Dallas field training

- Dallas recruits complete academy training and then a six-month field training period.
- Field training has four phases: three seven-week phases and a final three-week evaluation phase.
- The first and fourth phases use the same FTO. The second and third phases use other FTOs.
- Recruits begin observationally and gradually take a more active role in responding to calls.
- FTOs also provide frequent evaluations; the initial FTO later issues the final recommendation that determines whether the recruit graduates from field training.

Interpretation. The first FTO is not just another coworker. The first FTO is both a mentor and evaluator during a formative period, so this relationship can transmit practical judgment and behavioral norms.

2.2 Analytical sample

- The sample starts from the universe of 3.9 million calls for service received by Dallas PD from January 2013 to July 2019.

- The paper links calls to force reports, arrest data, Dallas County District Attorney filing outcomes, and officer characteristics.
- The main sample contains 521 recruits and 251 distinct Phase 1 FTOs.
- The analysis uses 1,198,564 post-training call-level observations in the main regressions.
- FTO-recruit pairings are inferred from field training dates and calls where recruits appear with senior officers, then checked against overtime pay data for FTO evaluation paperwork.

Interpretation. The unit of observation in the main outcome analysis is a call answered by a recruit after field training. The treatment is fixed at the recruit-FTO pair level.

2.3 Use-of-force outcome

- The main dependent variable equals one if a call ends in a recorded use of force by the recruit and zero otherwise.
- Force is measured through Dallas PD force reports and is linked to the incident identifier.
- The paper intentionally associates a force incident with officers on the scene, not only with the officer explicitly listed as applying force, because officers may affect one another’s behavior at the scene.
- The baseline force mean is 0.00116, or about 1.16 force incidents per 1,000 calls.
- Additional force outcomes include force with no arrest, force classified as unjustified/discretionary by the authors’ classification, and force with citizen injury.

Interpretation. The outcome is rare. This motivates randomization inference and robustness checks because asymptotic inference can be delicate for rare binary outcomes.

2.4 Measuring an FTO’s prior force propensity

The paper estimates a pair-specific FTO fixed effect using only calls answered by the FTO before that FTO trains recruit r :

$$\text{force}_{o(r),c} = \lambda_{o(r)} + \beta_1 X_c + \epsilon_{o(r),c}. \quad (1)$$

- $\text{force}_{o(r),c}$ equals one if call c answered by FTO o ends in force.
- X_c includes call characteristics: number of officers on scene, beat, call type, month, and day-of-week-by-night fixed effects.
- $\lambda_{o(r)}$ is the FTO’s prior propensity to use force for the specific recruit-FTO pairing.
- The same FTO can appear with different recruits at different dates, so $\lambda_{o(r)}$ is pair-specific rather than a single officer-wide statistic.

Interpretation. This measure isolates whether an FTO tends to use force more than peers when assigned to similar calls, beats, times, and call types.

2.5 Empirical Bayes shrinkage

Because force is rare and the pre-period length differs across pairings, the paper shrinks raw FTO fixed effects toward the mean:

$$\Lambda_{o(r)} = \frac{\sigma_A^2}{\sigma_A^2 + \sigma_W^2 / N_{o(r)}} \lambda_{o(r)}. \quad (2)$$

- σ_A^2 is across-officer variance in FTO force.

- σ_W^2 is within-officer residual variance.
- $N_{o(r)}$ is the amount of pre-period information for that FTO-recruit pairing.
- Pairings with fewer observations or more noise receive more shrinkage.
- The shrunken measure is then standardized into a z-score.

Interpretation. The standardized $\Lambda_{o(r)}$ lets coefficients be read as the effect of a one standard deviation increase in the FTO’s prior force propensity.

2.6 Call and recruit controls

- Recruit controls include age, gender, race, education, prior law enforcement experience, and prior training.
- Call controls include number of officers on scene, beat, call type/priority, year-by-month, and day-of-week-by-night fixed effects.
- Assignment controls use academy cohort by division fixed effects, matching the institutional assignment process.

Interpretation. The key identifying variation is within cohort-division cells, comparing recruits who were assigned to FTOs with different prior force propensities.

3 Models and empirical specifications

3.1 Main estimating equation

The paper estimates the following call-level model:

$$\text{force}_{r,c} = \theta_r + \beta_1 \Lambda_{o(r)} + \beta_2 X_c + \epsilon_{r,c}. \quad (3)$$

- $\text{force}_{r,c}$ equals one if recruit r uses force on call c after training.
- θ_r represents academy cohort by assigned division fixed effects.
- $\Lambda_{o(r)}$ is the standardized shrunken force propensity of recruit r ’s first FTO.
- X_c contains recruit and call controls.
- β_1 is the effect of being assigned to an FTO with one standard deviation higher prior force propensity.
- Standard errors are clustered at both the recruit and FTO levels.

Interpretation. A positive β_1 means that recruits trained by higher-force FTOs are more likely to use force on later calls, holding fixed the assignment cell and observed call/recruit characteristics.

3.2 Dynamic specification

To study persistence, the paper interacts FTO force with six-month post-training windows:

$$\text{force}_{r,c} = \theta_r + \sum_{t=0}^7 \beta_t \Lambda_{o(r)} \text{biannual}_t + \beta_2 X_c + \epsilon_{r,c}. \quad (4)$$

- biannual_t indexes six-month periods after field training ends.
- The coefficients β_t trace the effect over time since training.
- The specification includes the main controls from the fully saturated model.

Interpretation. The effect is positive during the first four six-month periods. This implies a roughly two-year persistence window.

3.3 Balance tests

The paper tests whether recruit characteristics predict FTO characteristics within the assignment cells:

$$FTOCharacteristic_{o(r)} = \alpha_{d,c} + \gamma RecruitCharacteristic_r + u_{r,o}. \quad (5)$$

- $\alpha_{d,c}$ is a division-by-cohort fixed effect.
- The outcomes are FTO age, gender, race, hire date, and FTO force rate.
- The regressors are recruit characteristics such as gender, race, education, prior law enforcement, training, and age categories.

Interpretation. If the assignment process is as good as random within division and cohort, recruit characteristics should not predict FTO characteristics. Table 2 supports this.

3.4 Mechanism and robustness specifications

The paper then repeats the main model while adding or changing controls and outcomes:

- force subtypes: force with no arrest, force with civilian injury, unjustified/discretionary force;
- subgroup estimates by recruit and FTO characteristics;
- randomization inference with simulated FTO assignments;
- alternative FTO behavior controls: arrest rate, response time, time on call, complaints, force with injury, and report writing;
- partner controls after training;
- other arrest outcomes.

Interpretation. These exercises ask whether the main relationship is really about FTO force thresholds rather than demographics, report behavior, call selection, continued exposure to the FTO, or a broader proactive-policing style.

4 Identification and empirical design

4.1 Source of variation

- Recruits do not choose their first FTO.
- Recruits are assigned to divisions based on staffing needs.
- Within division and cohort, command staff assign recruits to FTOs without knowledge of recruit characteristics or academy performance.
- The paper therefore treats first-FTO assignment as conditionally as good as random within division by academy cohort.

Interpretation. This is analogous to judge-stringency designs: the FTO’s prior force propensity is a quasi-randomly assigned style measure.

4.2 Balance evidence

- Table 2 shows no systematic relationship between recruit characteristics and FTO characteristics after division-by-cohort controls.
- None of the 60 main pairwise coefficient estimates is significant above conventional levels; only 3 are marginally significant.
- Joint tests and an omnibus test fail to reject balance.
- Some recruit characteristics predict recruit force use, which means the balance test has power to detect meaningful selection if it existed.

Interpretation. The strongest design feature is not just a verbal claim of random assignment. It is that the observed assignment patterns look balanced on variables that matter for recruit behavior.

4.3 Why call controls matter

- Call controls are not needed for random assignment of FTOs to recruits, but they help interpret mechanisms.
- Adding call controls attenuates the coefficient from 0.000203 to 0.000157.
- This suggests some of the raw effect may reflect call selection or proactive policing, but most of the effect remains.

Interpretation. The fully controlled specification estimates whether recruits use more force even when responding to comparable calls.

4.4 Threats and how the paper addresses them

- **Selection into FTOs:** addressed by institutional assignment rules and balance tests.
- **Selection into calls:** addressed by predicted-force checks and call fixed effects.
- **Measurement noise in FTO force:** addressed by empirical Bayes shrinkage.
- **Rare outcomes:** addressed by randomization inference.
- **Continued exposure to FTOs:** addressed by dropping calls with FTOs and controlling for post-training partners.
- **Reporting differences:** addressed by report-writing controls and evidence on reporting stability.
- **Broader policing style:** addressed by controls for FTO arrest rates, response time, time on call, complaints, and injury-related force.

Interpretation. The identifying claim is strongest for the effect of the first FTO. Later FTO assignments are less credible because command staff may know more about recruits by then.

5 Tables and figures

This section keeps the same *Read* plus *Economic message* format. Adjacent figures and tables are grouped together where useful to save space and speed up reading.

5.1 Figure 1 and Table 1: FTO force distribution and outcome rates

Read:

- Figure 1 shows the distribution of raw FTO fixed effects and empirical-Bayes-shrunken FTO effects.
- The shrunken distribution is tighter than the raw distribution, reflecting less weight on noisier estimates.
- The standardized measure implies that one standard deviation in FTO force corresponds to a 124 percent increase relative to the average force rate.
- Table 1 shows a baseline force rate of 0.00116 per call, or 1.16 per 1,000 calls.
- Calls answered by recruits trained by high-force FTOs have higher subsequent recruit force rates than calls answered by recruits trained by low-force FTOs.

Economic message. FTOs differ meaningfully in force propensity, and those differences line up with later recruit outcomes before any regression adjustment.

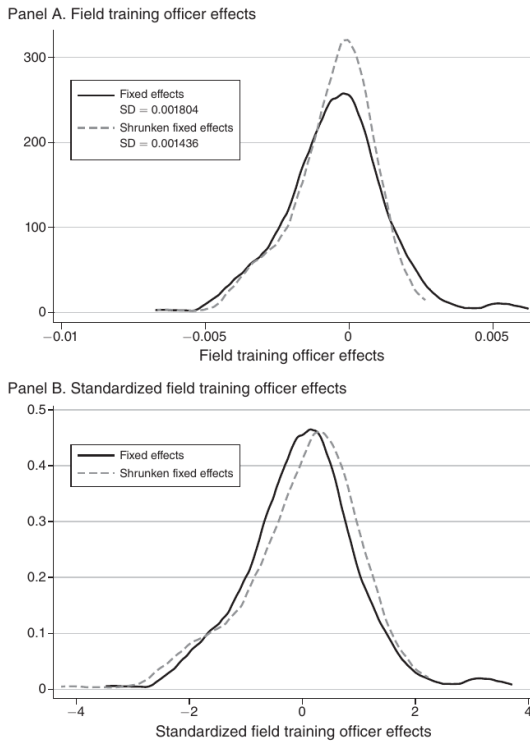


FIGURE 1. DENSITY OF FIELD TRAINING OFFICER PROPENSITY TO USE FORCE

(a) Figure 1: FTO force propensity.

	Entire sample (1)	High-force trainer (2)	Low-force trainer (3)
Force	0.00116 (0.0341)	0.00132 (0.0364)	0.000943 (0.0307)
Force with no arrest	0.000511 (0.0226)	0.000588 (0.0242)	0.000405 (0.0201)
Force unjustified	0.0000860 (0.00928)	0.000104 (0.0102)	0.0000618 (0.00786)
Force and civilian injured	0.000158 (0.0126)	0.000188 (0.0137)	0.000116 (0.0108)
Any arrest	0.0363 (0.187)	0.0366 (0.188)	0.0358 (0.186)
Misd. arrest	0.0212 (0.144)	0.0219 (0.146)	0.0202 (0.141)
Felony arrest	0.00731 (0.0852)	0.00726 (0.0849)	0.00739 (0.0857)
Filed arrest	0.0144 (0.119)	0.0143 (0.119)	0.0146 (0.120)
Unfiled arrest	0.0141 (0.118)	0.0149 (0.121)	0.0130 (0.113)
Observations	1,198,564	681,957	516,607
<i>Additional statistics</i>			
Average force per recruit per year	1.5		
Average force per recruit	3.25		

Notes: This table reports call-level summary statistics (means and standard deviations). High-force FTOs have higher force rates than the average FTO, and low-force FTOs have lower force rates than the average FTO. "Force unjustified" refers to force used when civilian resistance was minimal, specifically categorized as "furtive gesture," "not following commands," "null," or "off safety-no resistance." There are three types of arrests in our dataset: felony, misdemeanor, or n-class. Most n-class arrests are for outstanding warrants. We also categorize felony and misdemeanor arrests as filed or unfiled. If an arrest is unfiled, the district attorney decided not to move forward with the case, and the defendant will not be charged with a crime.

(b) Table 1: call-level outcome summary.

5.2 Table 2 and Figure 2: balance and raw relationship

Read:

- Table 2 tests whether recruit characteristics predict FTO characteristics within cohort-division cells.
- The balance tests show little evidence that recruit characteristics are systematically related to FTO age, gender, race, hire date, or force rate.
- The last columns show that recruit characteristics can predict recruit force, so imbalance would matter if present.

- Figure 2 panel A shows a clear positive relationship between FTO force rate and recruit actual force.
- Figure 2 panel B shows only a small relationship between FTO force rate and predicted force based on call covariates.

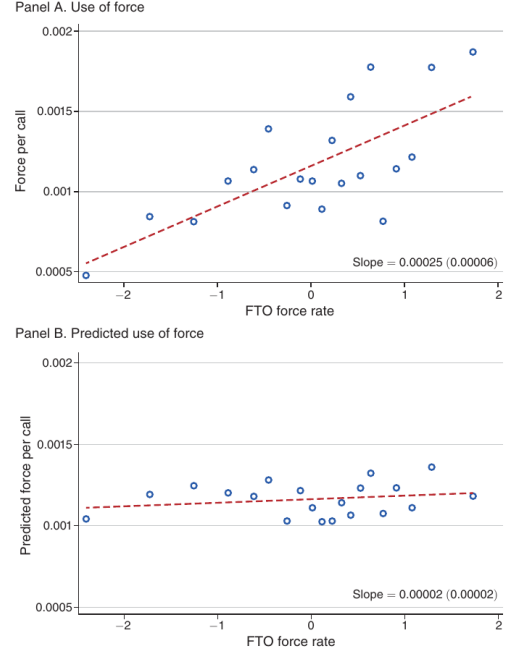
Economic message. The design passes balance checks, and the raw relationship is not fully explained by high-force FTO recruits merely taking more dangerous calls.

TABLE 2—BALANCE TEST

Recruit chars.	FTO characteristics						Recruit outcomes	
	Age	Female	Black	Hispanic	Hire date	FTO force	Recruit force	Recruit force NC
Female	-0.4661 (1.3053)	0.0137 (0.0445)	0.0620 (0.0529)	0.0342 (0.0481)	0.3789 (1.1767)	0.0000 (0.0002)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0000 (0.0001)
Black	-0.5571 (1.4275)	0.0634 (0.0477)	0.0867 (0.0585)	-0.0770 (0.0460)	0.1093 (1.2146)	-0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0002 (0.0001)
Hispanic	0.5837 (1.1288)	0.0544 (0.0436)	-0.0140 (0.0522)	0.0328 (0.0439)	-0.7922 (0.9791)	0.0000 (0.0002)	-0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
Prior law	0.7052 (2.2380)	-0.0278 (0.0811)	-0.0892 (0.0991)	-0.0915 (0.0724)	-0.7689 (1.8674)	0.0003 (0.0003)	0.0003 (0.0001)	0.0003 (0.0001)
Bachelors	-1.4008 (1.0387)	0.0213 (0.0329)	0.0257 (0.0472)	0.0131 (0.0362)	0.6346 (0.8823)	-0.0001 (0.0002)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
Masters	-4.0827 (2.7617)	-0.0469 (0.0868)	0.0536 (0.1226)	0.0912 (0.1259)	2.5177 (3.1131)	0.0001 (0.0003)	0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0000 (0.0002)
De-escalation training	1.5722 (4.6316)	-0.0430 (0.1501)	-0.1082 (0.1284)	0.2807 (0.1545)	2.5551 (4.2796)	-0.0004 (0.0007)	-0.0006 (0.0003)	-0.0005 (0.0003)
Crisis intervention training	0.6236 (3.7214)	0.1982 (0.1853)	0.1823 (0.1264)	-0.1812 (0.1084)	-1.6883 (4.0741)	-0.0009 (0.0006)	-0.0003 (0.0003)	-0.0004 (0.0003)
Age 30s	-0.1551 (1.1352)	0.0361 (0.0436)	0.0117 (0.0483)	-0.0192 (0.0430)	0.9462 (1.0836)	-0.0001 (0.0002)	0.0000 (0.0001)	-0.0001 (0.0001)
Age 40s	1.0537 (3.2497)	0.0870 (0.1276)	0.1627 (0.1657)	0.1003 (0.1519)	-0.1839 (2.7487)	-0.0004 (0.0006)	-0.0001 (0.0001)	-0.0002 (0.0001)
Div-x-cohort FE	X	X	X	X	X	X	X	X
Observations	521	521	521	521	521	521	521	521
Outcome mean	42.1382	0.1248	0.1843	0.1459	41.6620	-0.0005	-0.0000	0.0001
F-test p-value	0.885	0.883	0.269	0.157	0.959	0.511	0.318	0.028
Pairwise omnibus test	0.7953							
T-test exercise	Fail to reject 12/717 t-tests							

Notes: Columns report coefficients from regressing each FTO characteristic on all recruit characteristics (with FTO-clustered SEs and division-by-cohort fixed effects). Column F-tests assess joint significance. The bottom panel shows alternative specifications (robust and division-by-cohort clustered SEs). The pairwise omnibus test combines all 60 FTO-recruit characteristic pairs in a stacked regression with pair and division-by-cohort-by-pair fixed effects, and the t-test exercise conducts cohort-specific tests using Simes (1986) correction. The outcome

(a) Table 2: balance test.



(b) Figure 2: actual and predicted force.

5.3 Table 3 and Figure 3: main effect and subgroup patterns

Read:

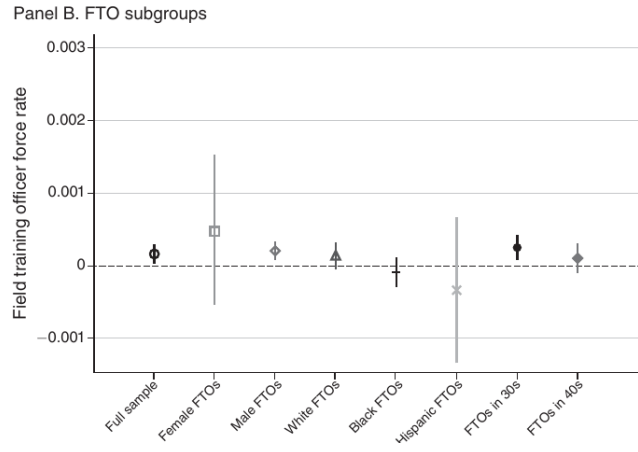
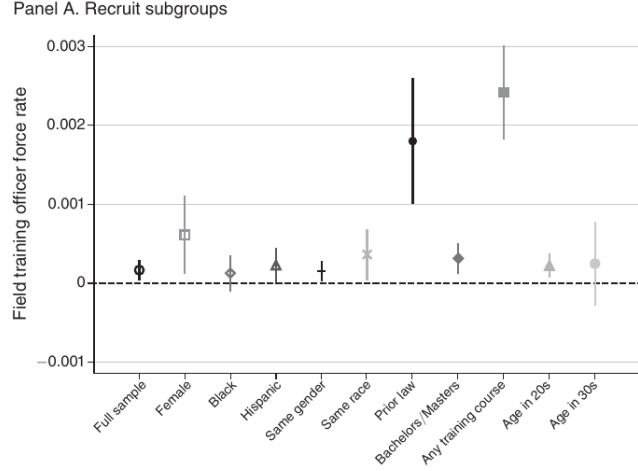
- Table 3 column 1 estimates 0.000206, implying an 18 percent increase relative to the 0.00116 baseline mean.
- Adding recruit controls in column 2 barely changes the estimate: 0.000203.
- Adding call controls in column 3 reduces the estimate to 0.000157, still economically meaningful and statistically significant.
- Figure 3 shows the effect is generally positive across recruit subgroups and FTO subgroups.
- Effects are especially large for recruits with prior law enforcement experience or training, though these groups have smaller samples.

Economic message. The main relationship is robust to controls and is not concentrated in only one demographic group.

	Force (1)	Force (2)	Force (3)
FTO force rate	0.000206 (0.0000658)	0.000203 (0.0000588)	0.000157 (0.0000604)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116
Assigned div by cohort fixed effects	Y	Y	Y
Recruit characteristics	—	Y	Y
Call controls	—	—	Y

Notes: This table presents the effect of FTO force rate on recruit use of force. Our primary regression specification is given by $\text{Force}_{i,t} = \theta_i + \beta_1 \Delta_{i,t} + \beta_2 X_{i,t} + \epsilon_{i,t}$ (equation (3)), where β_1 represents the effect of a 1 standard deviation increase in FTO force rate. Standard errors are multiway clustered at the field training officer and recruit levels. Column 2 includes controls for recruit characteristics (age, gender, race, prior law enforcement experience, education, and training course participation), while column 3 further adds call characteristic fixed effects (number of officers on the scene, beat, call type—priority-by-type, year-by-month, and day-of-week-by-night interactions). Standard errors in parentheses.

(a) Table 3: main effect.



(b) Figure 3: subgroup effects.

5.4 Figure 4 and Figure 5: persistence and randomization inference

Read:

- Figure 4 shows positive coefficients for the first four six-month windows after field training.
- After roughly two years, the estimated effects attenuate and become less precise.
- Figure 5 shows a randomization-inference distribution from 1,000 simulated FTO assignment processes.
- Only 42 simulations are more extreme than the baseline estimate in a two-sided test, corresponding to a randomization-inference p-value of 0.042.
- The one-sided p-value is 0.019.

Economic message. The effect is persistent and statistically unlikely under random reassignment of FTOs.

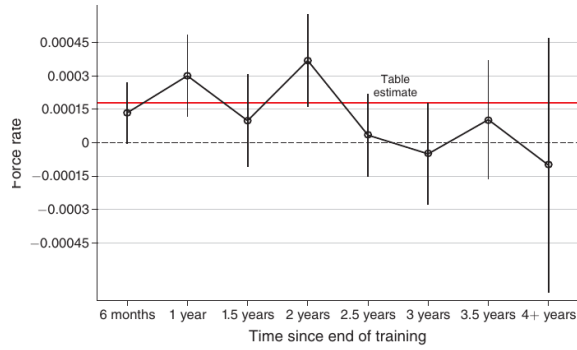


FIGURE 4. THE EFFECT OF FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON FORCE OVER TIME

figure shows how the effect of FTOs' use of force on recruits evolves over time since the end of training. The solid line represents the effect for a 6-month period, from 6 months up to 4+ years after training completion. The horizontal line marks the baseline estimate from the main analysis. Vertical lines show standard errors clustered at the FTO level. The analysis includes controls for call characteristics (number of officers present, time of call, year-month, and day-of-week-by-night) and recruit characteristics. The decreasing coefficients coincide with officers typically becoming eligible for promotion to senior corporal.

(a) Figure 4: effect over time.

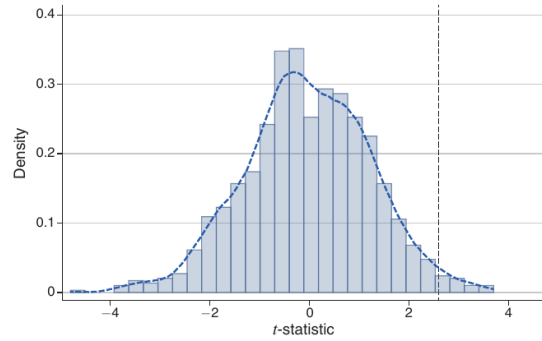


FIGURE 5. EMPIRICAL DISTRIBUTION OF t -STATISTICS FROM RANDOMIZATION INFERENCE

Figure reports the empirical distribution of t -statistics from estimating the regression shown in Table 3 by using 1,000 randomized simulations of the data-generating process. Only 42 of the simulations had t -statistics strictly greater than our baseline estimate, corresponding to a one-sided p -value of 0.042. A vertical dashed line marks our original t -statistic.

(b) Figure 5: randomization inference.

5.5 Table 4 and Table 5: force types and FTO behavior correlations

Read:

- Table 4 shows effects for force with no arrest, force with citizen injury, and unjustified/discretionary force.
- The no-arrest and unjustified-force outcomes are the most relevant to discretionary thresholds.
- Table 5 shows that FTO force is correlated with several other FTO behaviors, especially arrest-related measures and force with injury.
- FTO force is not strongly related to report-writing proxies in panel D.

Economic message. High-force FTOs differ in broader enforcement style, but this does not by itself explain the main recruit-force result.

TABLE 4—THE EFFECT OF HIGH-FORCE FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON RECRUIT USE OF FORCE (*by type*)

<i>Panel A. Force with no arrest</i>			
FTO force rate	0.0000836 (0.0000317)	0.0000816 (0.0000288)	0.0000624 (0.0000298)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.000511	0.000511	0.000511
<i>Panel B. Force with citizen injury</i>			
FTO force rate	0.0000302 (0.0000190)	0.0000312 (0.0000165)	0.0000240 (0.0000164)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.000158	0.000158	0.000158
<i>Panel C. Unjustified force</i>			
FTO force rate	0.0000229 (0.0000125)	0.0000217 (0.0000111)	0.0000188 (0.0000108)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.0000860	0.0000860	0.0000860
Assigned div by cohort fixed effects	Y	Y	Y
Recruit characteristics	—	Y	Y
Call controls	—	—	Y

Notes: This table presents the effect of being assigned a higher-force FTO on different types of recruit use of force. Standard errors are multiway clustered at the field training officer and recruit levels. Column 2 includes controls for recruit characteristics, such as age, gender, race, prior law enforcement experience, education, and training course participation. Column 3 further adds call characteristic fixed effects, including the number of officers on the scene, beat, call type (priority-by-type), year-by-month, and day-of-week-by-night interactions. Less justifiable force is classified by the authors based on recorded civilian resistance, that is, when civilian resistance was minimal, specifically categorized as “furtive gesture,” “not following commands,” “null,” “off safety—no resistance,” “closing reactionary gap,” “dead weight,” or “society Alabama.”

(a) Table 4: force by type.

TABLE 5—CORRELATION BETWEEN FTO FORCE RATE AND OTHER FTO BEHAVIOR

	Overall arrest rate	Filed arrest rate	Unfiled arrest rate	Misd. arrest rate	Felony arrest rate
<i>Panel A. FTO arrest</i>					
Force rate	0.457 (0.0678)	0.440 (0.0722)	0.338 (0.0602)	0.341 (0.0644)	0.496 (0.0722)
Observations	521	521	521	521	521
<i>Panel B. FTO timing and injury</i>					
	Response rate	Time on call	Force and injury rate		
Force rate	−0.0427 (0.0756)	−0.172 (0.0507)	0.368 (0.0559)		
Observations	521	521	521		
<i>Panel C. FTO complaints</i>					
	Complaints	UOF complaints	Internal complaints		
Force rate	0.0274 (0.0501)	0.132 (0.0535)	0.120 (0.0486)		
Observations	521	521	521		
<i>Panel D. FTO reporting</i>					
	Num. characters rate	Num. words rate	Write nothing rate		
Force rate	−0.0996 (0.0714)	−0.0885 (0.0704)	0.00487 (0.0707)		
Observations	514	514	514		
Div-by-cohort fixed effects	Y	Y	Y		

Notes: This table presents correlations between FTO force rate and other characteristics, estimated via regression of FTO characteristics on FTO force rate. All variables are standardized, and standard errors are clustered at the field training officer level. Response time is the hours between arrival and assignment. Time on call is the hours from en route to call clearance. We cannot link complaints to calls for service, so we compute complaints per call. Filed arrests were officially submitted to the District Attorney’s office, whereas unfiled arrests refer to incidents where an arrest was made but not filed with the DA’s office. Standard errors in parentheses.

(b) Table 5: correlations with other FTO behavior.

5.6 Table 6 and Table 7: mechanisms and partner selection

Read:

- Table 6 adds FTO demographics, other FTO behavior rates, recruit arrest controls, and a kitchen-sink specification.
- The original estimate is 0.000157; the kitchen-sink estimate is 0.000166, very similar in magnitude.
- Controlling for FTO force-with-injury attenuates the estimate to 0.000120, but it remains suggestive.
- Table 7 shows that post-training partner selection explains only a limited share of the main effect.
- The fully controlled recruit-force coefficient in Table 7 remains positive and statistically significant.

Economic message. The evidence favors norm/threshold transmission from the FTO over explanations based on demographics, general activity, or later partner choice.

TABLE 6—MECHANISMS: THE EFFECT OF HIGH-FORCE FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON RECRUIT USE OF FORCE

Variable	Coefficient (FTO force rate)	Standard error	p-value
Original estimate	0.000157	(0.0000604)	0.010
<i>FTO demographics</i>			
FTO gender	0.000165	(0.0000615)	0.008
FTO race	0.000164	(0.0000613)	0.008
FTO age	0.000167	(0.0000591)	0.005
<i>Other FTO rates</i>			
FTO arrest rate	0.000196	(0.0000628)	0.002
FTO misd. arrest rate	0.000176	(0.0000616)	0.005
FTO response time rate	0.000156	(0.0000606)	0.010
FTO time on call rate	0.000151	(0.0000599)	0.012
FTO complaint rate	0.000129	(0.0000600)	0.032
FTO force with injury rate	0.000120	(0.0000718)	0.096
<i>Recruit on-call actions</i>			
Recruit arrest	0.000152	(0.0000588)	0.010
Recruit arrest type	0.000154	(0.0000590)	0.010
<i>Kitchen sink</i>			
Kitchen sink model	0.000166	(0.0000586)	0.005
Outcome mean		0.00116	
Observations		1,198,564	
Assigned div by cohort fixed effects		Y	
Recruit characteristics		Y	
Call controls		Y	

Notes: This table presents the effect of the FTO force rate on recruit use of force. Standard errors are clustered at both the recruit and FTO levels. Each specification includes controls for recruit characteristics and fixed effects for call characteristics, including the number of officers on the scene, beat, call type (priority-by-type), and time variables (year-by-month and day-of-week-by-night). Row 1 replicates row 3 of Table 3. Rows 2–4 incorporate additional FTO characteristics, while rows 5–10 introduce controls for other FTO rates (see Supplemental Appendix B for details). Rows 11 and 12 account for whether a recruit made an arrest during the call and the type of arrest. Standard errors in parentheses.

TABLE 7—PARTNERS: THE EFFECT OF HIGH-FORCE FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON RECRUIT PARTNERS

	Force (1)	Partner force rate (2)	Force (3)	Partner force rate (4)	Force (5)	Partner force rate (6)
FTO force rate	0.000185 (0.0000609)	0.0726 (0.0427)	0.000182 (0.0000564)	0.0663 (0.0443)	0.000132 (0.0000561)	0.0650 (0.0440)
Observations	1,194,016	1,194,016	1,194,016	1,194,016	1,194,016	1,194,016
Outcome mean	0.00116	0.0259	0.00116	0.0259	0.00116	0.0259
Assigned div by cohort fixed effects	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Recruit characteristics	–	–	Y	Y	Y	Y
Call controls	–	–	–	–	Y	Y

Notes: This table presents the effect of the FTO force rate on the recruit's partner's force rate and the recruit's own use of force. Standard errors are multiway clustered at the recruit and FTO levels. Odd-numbered columns use recruit force as the outcome, while even-numbered columns use the recruit's partner's force rate. Only odd-numbered columns control for the recruit's most frequent partner post-training (the officer observed with them most in "little t"), including partner gender, race, and force rate. Columns 1 and 2 provide baseline estimates, controlling only for assigned division by cohort fixed effects. Columns 3 and 4 add recruit characteristics (age, gender, race, education, prior law enforcement experience, and de-escalation training). Columns 5 and 6 further introduce call controls (number of officers on the scene, beat, type of call, year-by-month, and day-of-week-by-night fixed effects). Standard errors in parentheses.

(a) Table 6: mechanism checks.

(b) Table 7: partner checks.

5.7 Table 8 and Table 9: reporting concerns and other arrests

Read:

- Table 8 repeats the main specifications while controlling for proxies for FTO report writing.
- The coefficients remain similar to Table 3, suggesting differential reporting is not the main driver.
- Table 9 examines arrests as other outcomes.
- High-force FTOs are associated with more lower-level arrest outcomes such as misdemeanor and unfilled arrests.
- Effects on more serious outcomes such as felony and filed arrests are smaller and less stable.

Economic message. The results are consistent with a lower threshold for discretionary enforcement rather than a broad improvement or deterioration in all enforcement activity.

TABLE 8—REPORTING CONCERNS: THE EFFECT OF HIGH-FORCE FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON RECRUIT USE OF FORCE

	Force (1)	Force (2)	Force (3)	Force (4)	Force (5)	Force (6)	Force (7)	Force (8)	Force (9)
FTO force rate	0.000207 (0.0000658)	0.000204 (0.0000590)	0.000159 (0.0000605)	0.000208 (0.0000656)	0.000205 (0.0000588)	0.000160 (0.0000604)	0.000206 (0.0000661)	0.000204 (0.0000588)	0.000156 (0.0000605)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116	0.00116
Div-cohort FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Recruit chars.	—	Y	Y	—	Y	Y	—	Y	Y
Call controls	—	—	Y	—	—	Y	—	—	Y
FTO # characters	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
FTO # words	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—
FTO write nothing	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	—

Notes: This table presents the effect of FTO force rate on recruit use of force. Standard errors are clustered at both the recruit and FTO levels. We also control for an FTO’s report-writing behavior—measured by the number of characters/words used and the frequency of leaving the section blank—using the “Modus Operandi (MO)” field from the incident report data. This open-ended field is completed by the reporting officer, and the resulting MO rates are calculated similarly to the force rates. Further details are provided in Supplemental Appendix B. Standard errors in parentheses.

(a) Table 8: reporting concerns.

TABLE 9—OTHER OUTCOMES: THE EFFECT OF HIGH-FORCE FIELD TRAINING OFFICERS ON RECRUIT ARRESTS

	Misd. arrest (1)	Misd. arrest (2)	Misd. arrest (3)	Unfiled arrest (4)	Unfiled arrest (5)	Unfiled arrest (6)
<i>Panel A. More petty arrests</i>						
FTO force rate	0.000585 (0.000367)	0.000596 (0.000385)	0.000415 (0.000297)	0.000524 (0.000304)	0.000609 (0.000318)	0.000395 (0.000223)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.0212	0.0212	0.0212	0.0141	0.0141	0.0141
	Felony arrest	Felony arrest	Felony arrest	Filed arrest	Filed arrest	Filed arrest
<i>Panel B. More serious arrests</i>						
FTO force rate	0.000583 (0.000148)	0.000592 (0.000142)	−0.00000455 (0.000122)	0.000131 (0.000247)	0.0000595 (0.000244)	0.0000273 (0.000218)
Observations	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564	1,198,564
Outcome mean	0.00731	0.00731	0.00731	0.0144	0.0144	0.0144
Assigned div by cohort FE	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y	Y
Recruit characteristics	—	Y	Y	—	Y	Y
Call controls	—	—	Y	—	—	Y

Notes: This table presents the effect of FTO force rate on recruit arrests. Standard errors are clustered at the recruit and FTO level. Columns 2 and 5 add controls for recruit characteristics (age, gender, race, education, prior law enforcement experience, and training). We add call characteristics fixed effects (number of officers on the scene, beat, type of call—priority-by-type, year-by-month, and day of the week by night) in columns 3 and 6. Unfiled

(b) Table 9: other arrest outcomes.

6 Short summary

- The paper studies whether FTOs transmit use-of-force behavior to new police recruits.
- The setting is the Dallas Police Department from 2013 to 2019.
- Field training is a six-month apprenticeship-style period after the academy.
- The first FTO is conditionally as good as randomly assigned within division and cohort.
- The paper measures each FTO’s prior force propensity using call-level data and call controls.
- Because force is rare and pre-period sample sizes vary, the FTO measure is shrunk with empirical Bayes and standardized.
- The main outcome is whether a recruit uses force on a post-training call.
- A one standard deviation increase in FTO force propensity raises recruit force use by 0.000157 to 0.000206 per call.
- Relative to the baseline force rate of 0.00116, this equals roughly 14 to 18 percent.
- Balance tests support conditional random assignment.
- Call controls reduce but do not eliminate the effect.
- Effects persist for about two years.
- Subgroup analyses show positive effects across most recruit and FTO groups.
- Randomization inference supports statistical significance.
- Mechanism tests weaken alternative explanations based on demographics, partners, proactive policing, reporting, and injury exposure.
- The authors interpret the evidence as transmission of norms or thresholds about the appropriate use of force.
- A policy simulation suggests that replacing the most forceful FTOs with low-force FTOs could meaningfully reduce recruit force incidents.

7 Conclusion

7.1 Core conclusion

Adger, Ross, and Sloan provide causal evidence that field training officers shape the later use-of-force behavior of police recruits. A recruit assigned to a higher-force FTO is more likely to use force after training, and this effect persists for about two years.

7.2 Economic intuition

The mechanism is a supervisor or apprenticeship effect. Recruits observe, practice, and receive evaluation from experienced officers during a high-stakes training period. If an FTO has a lower threshold for force, the recruit appears to adopt a lower threshold as well. This is not only a peer effect; it is a hierarchical training relationship where the senior officer has evaluative authority.

7.3 Takeaway

The paper shows that on-the-job training can transmit discretionary behavior in a high-stakes public-sector setting. For policing, FTO assignment and screening are potentially important reform levers. For labor economics, the paper demonstrates that supervisor effects can operate through norms and judgment, not only through productivity or routine task management.